

NEWS RELEASE

COMMONWEALTH OF PENNSYLVANIA

Department of Conservation and Natural Resources

Commonwealth News Bureau
Room 114, Main Capitol
Harrisburg, PA 17120

FOR IMMEDIATE RELEASE

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DCNR AWARDS NEARLY \$1.6 MILLION FOR PENNSYLVANIA RAIL-TRAILS

Pennsylvania Continues To Lead Nation in Number of Rail-Trails

HARRISBURG (May 6, 2004) — Conservation and Natural Resources Secretary Michael DiBerardinis today announced almost \$1.6 million in grants for the planning, acquisition and construction of more than 99 miles of rail-trails in 14 Pennsylvania counties.

Rail-trails are abandoned railroad beds converted for recreational uses such as hiking, biking, jogging and cross-country skiing.

“The value of rail-trails goes well beyond recreation,” Secretary DiBerardinis said. “They help our children get to school and other community places, improve local economies through tourism, provide a place for safe exercise, protect our open spaces and connect us with our neighbors.

“Although we lead the nation in the number of rail trails, we could be doing more to promote and encourage these and other trails as vibrant parts of our community living,” Secretary DiBerardinis said. “We need the Governor’s proposed 2004-05 budget to provide the funding momentum to continue the important trail work already under way in many areas of the state.”

Governor Edward G. Rendell’s proposed expansion and renewal of the state’s current Growing Greener program would invest in projects that return brownfields and other polluted sites to productive use; protect farmland and open space from development; clean up polluted streams and abandoned mines; improve state parks and community recreation; and promote the use of clean energy. The Governor’s plan builds on the work of previous administrations and will require a voter-approved \$800 million bond issue to fund the initiative.

The Rails-to-Trails grants are a component of DCNR’s Community Conservation Partnerships Program, funded by the Keystone Recreation Park and Conservation Fund and the current Growing Greener fund. Rail-trail grants provide up to 50 percent of the funding for planning, acquisition and development of rail-trail corridors. This year the Community Conservation Partnerships Program grants are only meeting about 40 percent of the demand.

Creating trail and greenways connections within and among communities is a goal outlined in Pennsylvania’s Greenways Plan, a comprehensive 20-year strategy unveiled in 2001. “Pennsylvania Greenways: An Action Plan for Creating Connections” provides a framework for developing a network of greenways, connecting corridors of open space, natural landscape features and recreational sites statewide. Rail-trails are a vital component of the plan.

Pennsylvania leads the nation in the number of rail-trails with 116 open trails, according to the Rails-to-Trails Conservancy’s Pennsylvania office. Over the last decade, Pennsylvania has nearly tripled the number of miles of rail-trails to the current 1,257 from 432 in 1995.

For more information on the rails-to-trails program and grants, call (717) 783-2658 or visit www.dcnr.state.pa.us. More information on Growing Greener II is available at www.growinggreener2.com.

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EDITOR’S NOTE: A list of grants is attached.

2004 Rails-To-Trails Grants

ALLEGHENY COUNTY

Montour Trail Council, \$90,000 – to construct a 115-foot bridge over Piney Fork Run on the Montour Trail.

Urban Redevelopment Authority of Pittsburgh, \$250,000 – to rehabilitate the Hot Metal Bridge to provide a connection to the Three Rivers Heritage Trail and the Great Allegheny Passage.

CLARION AND JEFFERSON COUNTIES

Tri County Rails To Trails Association, \$100,000 – to acquire 41 miles of abandoned railroad from Brockway to Piney for development of a trail.

COLUMBIA AND MONTOUR COUNTIES

SEDA-Council of Governments, \$50,000 - to determine the feasibility of developing a trail along the historic North Branch Pennsylvania Canal from Danville to Benton.

FAYETTE COUNTY

Fayette County, \$55,000 – to complete the design of 10.4 miles of the Sheepskin Trail North.

LEHIGH COUNTY

Whitehall Township, \$35,000 - to further develop the Ironton Rail-Trail, including construction of parking area, installation of ADA access, fencing, pavilion, landscaping, sign and other related site improvements.

LUZERNE COUNTY

Susquehanna Warrior Trail Council, \$150,000 - to further develop 5 miles of the Susquehanna Warrior Trail.

NORTHAMPTON COUNTY

Bethlehem City, \$100,000 – to acquire about 10 acres of abandoned railway in the City of Bethlehem between Hill to Hill Bridge and Hayes Street for use as a pedestrian and bicycle trail.

PHILADELPHIA COUNTY

Fairmount Park Commission, \$250,000 - to further develop 1.8 miles of the Kensington & Tacony Trail.

SNYDER COUNTY

Snyder County, \$20,000 - to study the feasibility of developing a 15-mile rail-trail in western Snyder County from McClure Borough to Middleburg Borough, including the villages of Paxtonville and Beaver Springs; Beavertown Borough; and West Beaver, Spring, Beaver, and Franklin townships.

VENANGO COUNTY

Allegheny Valley Trails Association, \$100,000 - to further develop 6 miles of the Allegheny River Trail from Rockland Tunnel to Emlenton.

WASHINGTON COUNTY

Washington County, \$70,000 - to further develop 4.25 miles of the Panhandle Trail from Station Street to Dinsmore Road.

McDonald Area Redevelopment Association, \$37,000 – to renovate and further develop the McDonald Trail Station/Meeting House as part of the Allegheny Trail Association’s “Trail Towns” initiative.

WESTMORELAND COUNTY

Alle-Kiski Revitalization Corporation, \$200,000 – to acquire a permanent trail easement on 7.8 miles along the Allegheny River in the boroughs of Oakmont and Plum in Allegheny County and the cities of New Kensington and Arnold in Westmoreland County.

Westmoreland County, \$80,000 – to further develop the Five Star Trail, including a pedestrian bridge over Sewickley Creek in New Stanton.

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